so after the crisis, he seems to have done so from memory. Memoirs have value, but inevitably tell us what the person writing them can remember, and, moreover, what she or he wants us to know. Recordings and transcripts provide details of what was said in specific contexts, even though they often cannot convey how or why it was said, or with what effect. And obviously they cannot tell us about meetings that were not recorded.

Similarly, contemporaneous documents are written for a purpose. They may reflect what those writing them want others to know; records of crucial exchanges may not have been made, or been lost, or are still stored in archives, awaiting declassification that in some cases may never come. The Cuban missile crisis is an immensely valuable resource for understanding the challenges (and opportunities) of writing history. Nevertheless, history is not simply a narrative (or sets of narratives). It is a debate about the past. Often, it is a debate about how the past informs (or reflects) the present. Frequently, it is a debate about how the past should inform the future.

Toward the end of the 1980s, in keeping with the spirit and purposes of Mikhail Gorbachev's *glasnost*, Soviet officials began to tell their stories about the crisis (most notably in the critical oral history conferences). Historians also began to gain access to Soviet archives (albeit access that was limited and controlled by the authorities). This facilitated invaluable studies of Soviet decision-making. For the first time, there were archive-based Cold War studies of a kind that Western historians had produced for many years. It became possible to see the crisis from 'the other side of the hill' (or hills when the Cubans were involved). A more genuinely *international* history of international history emerged.

One of the most significant studies of the crisis was published in 1997 by Aleksandr Fursenko and Timothy Naftali: *'One Hell of a Gamble': Khrushchev, Castro, Kennedy, and the Cuban Missile Crisis 1958–1964.*[14] This combined use of Western sources with those from Moscow (and to some extent from Havana). Fursenko and Naftali's work reflected unprecedented access to a range of Soviet-era records, including those of the Presidium, the Foreign Ministry, the Ministry of Defence, Soviet Military Intelligence (GRU), and the Committee for State Security (KGB).